(‘nectar’) necklace and still worn by the *murti* on all ceremonial processions.

Another form of now popular mythology relating to British involvement in religious affairs presents the local administration in the role of vandal or robber. One such example comes from the magnificent Chola temple in Chidambaram, dedicated to Lord Shiva as the cosmic dancer Nataraja. This was at one time staggeringly wealthy, thanks to centuries of royal patronage and donations of land, money and jewellery, much of it originating from the war booty of the Imperial Cholas. As related in an earlier chapter, this made the temple prey to raiders, but if you go on the temple’s website you will learn that this treasure was stolen by the British:

> During the British era, they took over many temples because of the enormous amount of wealth attached to them and all the jewellery has completely disappeared today. They say that a huge amount of the British funding for World War II came from Indian temples. Lands were also taken over and distributed, so the temple has become poor and unmanageable now.

These are the words of Sadhguru Jaggi Vasudev of Coimbatore, respected yogi and yoga-teacher, and leading light of the Isha Foundation. The Sadhguru is the inspiration behind the very laudable environmental initiative known as Project GreenHands, which over the course of three days in 2004 planted more than eight hundred and fifty thousand saplings in 6284 locations in Tamil Nadu, involving no fewer than a quarter of a million volunteers, and which has since set up greening movements and plant nurseries in Tirupur, Karur, Madurai, Dindigul and Trichy.

If the Sadhguru were to re-examine the issue of Chidambaram he would find that initially the British authorities in the Madras Presidency were reluctant to get